

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1547

By Pearson

A RESOLUTION to honor September 22 as "Veterans Suicide Prevention Day" in Tennessee.

WHEREAS, suicide is a major public health issue and among the top ten causes of death in the United States; unfortunately, for more than a decade, the suicide rate has been rising in the general U.S. population and especially among veterans, the very men and women who risked their lives for their country; and

WHEREAS, in its 2018-2024 strategic plan, the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) identified preventing veteran suicide as its highest clinical priority; and

WHEREAS, there were 6,407 veteran suicide deaths in the United States in 2022, an average of 17.6 veteran suicide deaths per day; and

WHEREAS, in 2022, suicide was the twelfth leading cause of death for veterans, the fourth leading cause of veterans' years of potential life lost, and the second leading cause of death for veterans under forty-five years of age; and

WHEREAS, the suicide rate among male veterans was higher in 2022 than in all the years between 2001-2022; and

WHEREAS, in 2022, there were 184 veteran suicide deaths in Tennessee, an average of 41.3 such deaths per 100,000 population; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee's veterans suicide rate exceeds those of the Southern Region and the U.S., is significantly higher than the general suicide rates for the State and Southern Region, and is approaching a crisis in the U.S.; and

WHEREAS, screening veterans for suicide risk in mental health, emergency, and primary care settings can detect those veterans who might be thinking about harming

themselves, discern their current level of risk, and provide opportunities to offer appropriate care, ultimately reducing suicide attempts; and

WHEREAS, as part of its National Strategy for Preventing Veteran Suicide, VA developed Risk ID, a three-stage suicide screening process that has been implemented successfully in VA settings; and

WHEREAS, caring contacts, which are brief, personal, nondemanding follow-up messages sent to veterans after they receive care, have been linked to decreased suicide attempts; and

WHEREAS, VA is expanding its Caring Contacts program based on this promising evidence that such contacts can save lives; and

WHEREAS, efforts to promote community-based approaches to suicide prevention have been launched by the Center for Disease Control (CDC) through its community prevention framework, which includes seven components, ranging from providing economic support to promoting connectedness, that help to create a protective environment; and

WHEREAS, VA has partnered with the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration and communities across America to create and implement suicide prevention plans targeting service members, veterans, and their families at the State and local levels; and

WHEREAS, additional research on this important topic is needed, as are additional programs to provide support for and prevent suicide among veterans, our most distinguished citizens who sacrificed their freedom and risked their lives in service of their fellow Americans; and

WHEREAS, National Suicide Prevention Month is observed annually in September; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE

CONCURRING, that in appreciation of our veterans' gallant service, we honor September 22 as "Veterans Suicide Prevention Day" in Tennessee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.